

Career Development Session Summary

Today we listened to Kelly Masegian from the SJSU Career Center present the steps required to build a complete and ATS-compatible resume that will get you noticed by a human recruiter. The Career Center, located in Clark Hall, helps students with internship searches, career exploration, and resume help, and Kelly is one of the many advisors available within ENG building 116 or over Zoom. The Career Center is going to run the STEM Launch Your Career, a series of career counseling events for STEM undergraduates, on September 9th and 10th. Three other resources were also mentioned: LinkedIn Learning, OpenAI, and Hiration, all available for free via our SJSU emails.

The bulk of the session focused on how to create a practical and powerful resume. The core idea is to tell the truth while being honest and displaying your skills and personal traits. She explained that an organization's background check only has access to your past company, position, and duration at the position, not your performance or any other factors. Skill levels should not be specified on the resume and should be later explained via an interview. The exception to this rule is if you place any alternative languages on your resume. In this case, you must use your own discretion and place a skill level for the skill. Alumni connections are worth using and making as they can help you gain insider information to open positions in the future. Resumes should be one page only, or two pages if you have over 10 years of experience. Federal jobs require the use of CVs, which can be 3-5 pages long. Recruiters only spend approximately 7 seconds per resume to determine whether they are interested in the candidate. If they are interested, then they will spend another 30 seconds on the resume and then 30 seconds on the candidate's LinkedIn profile of the candidate. Placing outside or unrelated experience on your resume is acceptable if it connects to your character traits related to your employment, but high school experience should be considered too outdated. Current-semester experience can be included in your resume and added as it is learned. For me, this would include Packet Tracer, circuit building, and Python. The recommended order on your resume is Education first as the spotlight, followed by Skills and Projects, then Experience.

The formatting for a resume is crucial as they are forced through an ATS. Resumes should avoid using alternate colored fonts, different content organization, and images. The ATS reads from left to right and converts the file to a .txt file before reading, so the images and cosmetic features will ruin the integrity of your resume. The only personal information that should be included in your resume is your city and zip code, as well as any personal links and your email(s). The look should be black and white with a basic sans-serif font like Arial or Calibri with 0.75 to 1 inch margins. There should be no header or footer, and the dates for your education should only include your projected graduation date. Filler words such as "successfully" should be cut, and each sentence should begin with an action verb. Everything should be written in the third person, so the voice of "I" should be avoided.

I understand that writing a good resume isn't about nailing it on the first try. It takes many revisions and alterations to make your resume both stick out to an AI and a human recruiter, and I know that as I progress further through college, I will build more skills and slowly discard the irrelevant fluff from my resume.